

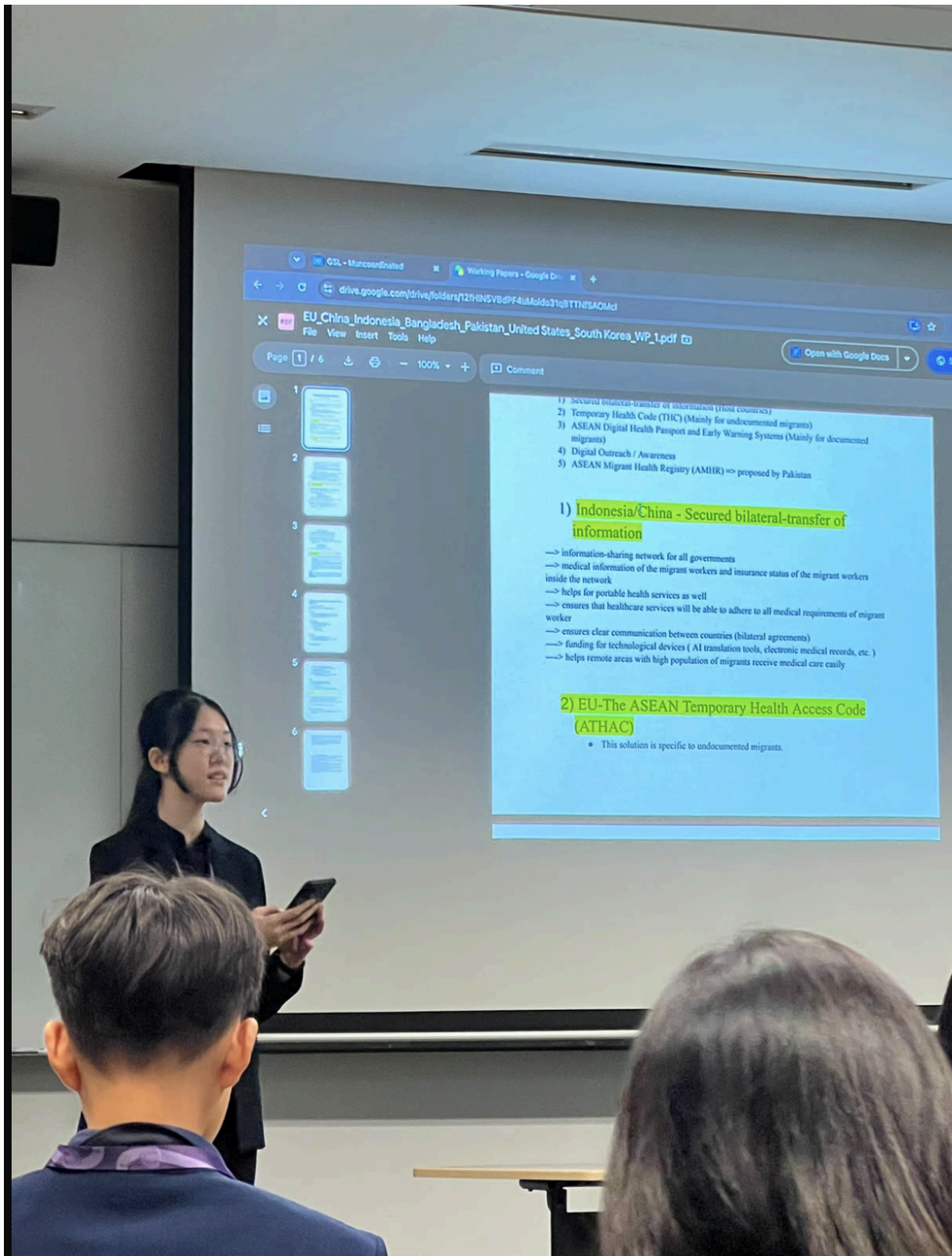
Opinion-Editorial

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Topic: ASEAN Health Ministers Meeting on Migrant Workers' Healthcare Rights

Indonesia collaborates with non-ASEAN countries to improve healthcare coverage for migrant workers



The Minister of Indonesia addressing questions from the council

Migrant workers are fundamental to the development of many ASEAN countries and Indonesia is no exception. Indonesia benefits greatly from the invaluable labour and expertise and in return, seeks to support migrant workers through a multilateral approach.

During the ASEAN Health Ministers Meeting, Indonesia championed for a pragmatic approach to ASEAN migrant workers' healthcare. By prioritizing bilateral agreements and information-sharing, Indonesia aims to ensure accessible and equitable healthcare for all residents of Indonesia, including migrant workers who have crossed borders to earn a livelihood here.

The Minister of Indonesia has secured a bilateral transfer of information with the Minister of China. Both countries are working together to form a digital database containing the medical information and insurance statuses of migrant workers to ensure a seamless healthcare experience for all.

Moreover, migrants will present different healthcare challenges. The aforementioned internet-sharing network will support timely medical assistance that will adhere to all medical requirements of migrant workers.

However, this is not an issue that can be solved simply with funding.

Jakarta consistently emphasizes that social justice should be upheld at the forefront of all issues. While insurance frameworks and equitable access to healthcare is part of the solution, the fundamental question of 'Why do migrant workers face health issues so frequently?' lies unanswered.

Migrant workers often stay in unsanitary and uninhabitable conditions, creating a breeding ground for an onset of diseases. This problem is exacerbated by the lack of clean water and nutritious food.

With their limited understanding of the language and culture, they face barriers of xenophobia and discrimination in the healthcare sector as well.

To improve the health of migrant workers, the first thing to address is their living conditions. Providing clean water and proper sanitation is vital to prevent the spread of diseases. When workers live in overcrowded and dirty spaces, healthcare access alone is insufficient when the root cause is not solved.

Nutritious food is another essential need that is often lacking. Due to low wages and insufficient cooking facilities, many migrant workers rely on cheap meals that fail to provide adequate nutrition. This lack of nutritious food weakens their immune systems, making them more susceptible to illness and injuries at work.

Another significant challenge is the lack of time. Migrant workers often endure long hours with very few days off. They typically do not have time during the day to actually visit any healthcare facilities. As most migrant workers get paid by the hour, they would rather continue working for the sake of their livelihoods than risk losing a day's pay for treatment.

To address this, low wages must first be increased to reduce the number of hours migrant workers work just to get by.

This is an issue the society faces as a whole. The current system in place must be supplemented with additional infrastructure for healthcare coverage to be effective in the first place.

Ultimately, resolving this crisis first requires addressing such everyday challenges. True social justice means ensuring that those who contribute to our economy have safe housing, adequate food, and the time to take care of their health.

Migrant workers are not merely labourers, they are sons and daughters, parents and grandparents, and friends to all of us.

Annotated Bibliography

This article details the personal account of a persecuted Vietnamese journalist to highlight the severe lack of press freedom in the country. It focuses on the intensifying government campaign to silence independent media voices and critical reporting.

<https://rsf.org/en/my-case-clearly-shows-there-absolutely-no-press-freedom-vietnam-says-persecuted-journalist>

This report examines upcoming legislative changes in Vietnam designed to widen the definition of state secrets. It explains how these laws make it significantly harder for journalists to protect confidential sources, further restricting investigative journalism.

<https://www.straitstimes.com/asia/se-asia/vietnam-set-to-make-it-harder-for-media-to-protect-sources-to-expand-state-secrets>

This analysis looks at Vietnam's defensive stance toward external social protection frameworks. It questions the sustainability of models that rely heavily on wealthy nations funding local programs rather than fostering true mutual collaboration.

<https://www.social-protection.org/gimi/Media.action?id=10956>

This resource provides a clear breakdown of Indonesia's national employment social security program, BPJS Ketenagakerjaan. It explains how the system protects local and migrant workers against risks like workplace injuries, old age, and death.

<https://asanify.com/glossary/bpjs-ketenagakerjaan/>

This legal study analyzes the domestic regulations and enforcement mechanisms used to safeguard Indonesian workers. It highlights the gaps between national laws and the actual protection workers receive when deployed overseas.

<https://journal.uib.ac.id/index.php/jlpt/article/download/9120/3894>

This article explores the bilateral governance and diplomatic challenges between Indonesia and Malaysia regarding migrant labor. It focuses on how policy gaps affect the legal protection and social security rights of Indonesian workers.

https://socialpolicyworldwide.org/post/governance_and_the_protection_of_indonesian_migrant_workers_in_malaysia_41

This ILO report addresses the specific health and safety challenges faced by female Indonesian migrant workers. It emphasizes the need for targeted policies to combat gender-based discrimination and health disparities in the workplace.

<https://www.ilo.org/resource/news/protecting-health-rights-indonesian-migrant-workers-against-gender-based>

This is the official legal text of Indonesia's landmark 2017 law, which shifted the focus from merely managing migration to actively protecting the rights and welfare of migrant workers and their families.

<https://asean.org/wp-content/uploads/2016/05/Law-of-Indonesia-No-18-of-2017-on-Protection-of-Indonesian-Migrant-Workers.pdf>

This comprehensive report offers data and analysis on regional migration trends across Southeast Asia. It examines the economic drivers of migration and evaluates the effectiveness of current ASEAN policies on labor mobility.

<https://asean.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/08/ASEAN-Migration-Outlook-Final.pdf>

This global fact sheet from the World Health Organization outlines the fundamental health challenges that displaced people and migrant workers face. It highlights the systemic, economic, and cultural barriers preventing access to quality care.

<https://www.who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/refugee-and-migrant-health>

This article gives a localized perspective on the daily lives and medical struggles of migrant workers in Singapore. It focuses on grassroots efforts to provide accessible healthcare and bridge cultural gaps within host communities.

<https://healthserve.org.sg/story/an-outsiders-look-into-migrant-workers-in-singapore/>